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Plastic wins over paper in UCB battle of the mugs

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BERKELEY -- The University of California, Berkeley has declared war on throw-away paper coffee cups, saying they produce litter and they're not environmentally friendly.

So despite looming budget cuts likely to reach into the millions, the university has coughed up $10,000 for a solution to the paper cup problem: Buy 5,000 reusable plastic coffee mugs and give them free to students.

The initial cost is estimated at about $7,500, university officials say.

That may seem like a lot of money, says Lisa Bauer, director of Campus Recycling and Refuse Services, but do the math. "There are 30,000 students on campus. They're here for four years and let's say they're on campus for 200 days a year.

"At least half of them will get a paper cup filled with coffee or tea or something every day," she said. "Some people, of course, get three or four cups. When you figure it out the number of cups used in a year is astronomical."

The math says: 4 million cups a year.

"If you really look at the cradle to grave costs of paper cups, starting with the trees cut down to make the paper, then $7,000 or $8,000 for permanent cups doesn't seem like so much," she said.

"UC Davis, UC Irvine, Harvard and Brown universities have similar programs, so we're not exactly on the cutting edge here," she said.

Bauer designed the sturdy, 20 ounce cups, made from 40 percent recycled plastic and 60 percent virgin plastic, in 2001. The university handed out several thousand to incoming freshmen in 2001.

But the program languished until this past weekend, when Graduate Student Assembly President Jessica Quindel proposed renewing the disposable cup program at the university's recycling summit.

The meeting, held to help UC Berkeley move toward a more sustainable environment, was organized by Associated Students members Ian Wagner, Haden Tesfai and Alicia Sweeney -- who quickly endorsed the cup idea.

But even cup program supporters -- aware that students have just coughed up about $100 each per semester in fee increases and no doubt face more increases in coming semesters -- admitted they were surprised the university immediately agreed to fork over the cash.

But, Quindel said, "the reality is that in the long run -- if people actually use the cups and stop using disposable paper, it would cut down on waste on campus and eventually it would make our planet a better place."

UC students drink a lot of coffee, says Associated Students President Jesse Gabriel. "They throw away thousands of cups every single day. We're trying to get a change of culture. All the campus coffee shops have agreed to offer a discount.

"And off-campus, we've got so many coffee shops, it's ridiculous. I don't know any other place in the world that has so many," Gabriel said.

Many of the off-campus cappuccino shops have agreed to a 10-cent a cup discount for students who produce their own mugs, he said.

Those signing on include Caffe Strada, Cafe Milano and the many Starbucks.

Associated Students intends to hand out the cups, one to a student, as students register and vote in the upcoming Associated Students election.

"I don't mean to be political," Bauer said, "but these days whenever there's a budget squeeze, it's always the environmental programs that get cut."

She said she's happy the university is taking a long view on the issue.

It's a small price to pay for the paradigm shift that needs to happen among students, to make them realize that even something like a paper cup has a real cost, she said.

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